Ineffabilis Deus

Pius IX · 1854-12-08 · English

LETTERS APOSTOLIC OF OUB MOST HOLT FATHER PIUS IX., BY DIVINE PROVIDENCE POPE, CONCERNING THE DOGBIATIC DEFINITION OF THE IMMACULATE CON- CEPTION OF THE VIRGIN MOTHER OF GOD.

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dFor a perpetual remem&ranee*

God who is ineffable, whose ways are mercy and truth, whose will is omnipotence, and whose wisdom reaches powerfully from end to end, and sweetly disposes all things, when He foresaw from all eternity the most sorrow- ful ruin of the enlire human race to follow jfrom the transgression of Adam, and in a mystery hidden from ages determined to com- plete, through the Incarnation of the Word, in a more hidden sacrament; the first work of His goodness; so that man, led into sin by

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the craft of diabolical iniquity, should not perish contrary to His merciful design; and that what was about to befall in the first Adam should be restored more happily in the Second; — from the beginning and before ages chose and ordained a Mother for His only-begotten Son, of whom made flesh, He should be bom in the blessed plenitude of time, and He loved Her above all other creatures, that in Her alone He pleased Himself with a most benign complacency. Wherefore, far before all the Angelic Spirits and all the Saints, He so wonderfully endowed Her with the abundance of all the heavenly gifts drawn from the treasure of divinity, that She might be ever free from every st^n of sin, and all fair and perfect, and might possess that ple- nitude of innocence and holiness than which, under God, none is greater, and which, except God, no one can reach even in thought. And indeed it was most becoming that She should

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be always adorned with the splendor of the most perfect holiness, and free even from the very stain of original sin, should gain a most complete triumph over the ancient serpent, — the Mother so venerable, to whom God the Father gave His only Son, whom begotten and equal to Himself He loved as Himself, in such a manner that He would be by na- ture One and the Same common Son of God the Father, and of the Virgin, and whom the Son himself chose to make substantially His Mother, and from whom the Holy Ghost willed and operated that He should be con- ceived and bom from whom He himself pro- ceeds.

Which original innocence of the august Virgin agreeing completely with her admira- ble holiness, and with the most excellent dig- nity of the Mother of God, the Catholic Church, which, ever taught by the Holy Spirit, is the pillar and ground of Truth, as possessing a

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doctrine divinely received, and comprehended in the deposit of heavenly revelation, has never ceased to lay down, to cherish, and to illustrate continually by numerous proofs, arid daily more and more by splendid facts- For this doctrine, flourishing from the most ancient times, and implanted in the minds of the Faithful, and by the care and zeal of the holy PontiflFs wonderfully propagated, the Church herself has most clearly pointed out when she did not hesitate to propose the Con- ception of the same Virgin for the public de- votion and veneration of the Faithful. By which illustrious act she pointed out the Con- ception of the Virgin as singular, wonderful, and very far removed from the origin of the rest of mankind, and to be venerated as en- tirely holy, since the Church celebrates festi- val days only of what is holy. And, there- fore, the very words in which the Sacred Scriptures speak of the Uncreated Wisdom

and represent His eternal origin, she has been accustomed to use not only in the offices of the Church, hut also in the holy Liturgy, and to apply to the origin of that Virgin, which was preordained by one and the same decree with the incarnation of the Divine Wisdom. But though all those things everywhere justly received amongst the Faithfiil show with what zeal the Eoman Church, the Mo- ther and Mistress of all Churches, has sup- ported the doctrine of the Immaculate Con- ception of the Virgin, yet the illustrious acts of this Church are evidently worthy that they should be reviewed by name ; since, so great is the dignity and authority of the same Church, and so much due to her who is the centre of Catholic Truth and Unity, in whom alone religion has been inviolably guarded, and from whom it is right that all the Churches should receive the tradition of Faith. Thus the same Eoman Church had

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nothing more at heart than to assert, to pro- tect, to promote, and to vindicate in the most eloquent manner the Immaculate Conception of the Virgin, its devotion, and doctrine, which fact so many illustrious acts of the Eoman PontiflFs, Our predecessors, most evi- dently and fully testify and declare, to whom in the person of the Prince of the Apostles was divinely committed by Christ our Lord the supreme care and power of feeding

the lambs and sheep, of confirming the brethren, and of ruling and governing the universal Church.

Indeed, Our predecessors vehemently glo- ried to institute in the Eoman Church by their own Apostolic authority the Feast of the Conception, and to augment, ennoble, and promote with all their power the devotioij thus instituted, by a proper Office and Mass, by which the prerogative of immunity from hereditary stain was most manifestly as-

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serted; and to increase it either by indul- gences granted, or by leave given to states, provinces, and kingdoms, that they might choose as their Patroness the Mother of God, under the title of Her Immaculate Concep- tion; or by approved sodalities, congrega- tions, and religious societies, instituted in honor of the Immaculate Conception; or by praises given to the piety of those who have erected monasteries, hospitals, or churches, under the title of the Immaculate Conception, or who have bound themselves by a religious vow to defend strenuously the Immaculate Conception of the Mother of God. Above all, they were happy to ordain that the Feast of the Conception should be celebrated through the whole Church as that of the Nativity; and, in fine, that it should be celebrated with an Octave in the universal Church, and be placed in the rank of the festivals which are commanded to be kept holy by all; also that

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a Pontifical fiinction should be celebrated yearly in Our Patriarchal libeiian Basilica on the day sacred to the Conception of the Virgin; desiring to cherish daily more and more in the minds of the Faithful this doc- trine of the Immaculate Conception of the Mother of God, and to excite their piety to the worship and veneration of the Virgin conceived without original sin, they have gladly given leave that in the Litany of Lo- retto and in the Preface of the Mass itself should be proclaimed the Immaculate Con- ception of the same Virgin, and that thus the law of faith should be established by the law of prayer. We ourselves, treading in the footsteps of so many Predecessors, have not only received and approved what had been most wisely and piously established and ap- pointed by them, but also, mindful of the in- stitution of Sixtus IV., We have appointed by our authority a proper Office of the Im-

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maculate Conception, and with a most joyful mind have gi^anted the use of it to the uni- versal Church.

But since those things which pertain to worship are evidently bound by an intimate chord to its object, and cannot remain fixed and detennined, if that be doubtful, and re- main in uncertainty, our predecessors the Eoman Pontiffs, increasing with all their care the devotion of the Conception, studied most especially to declare and inculcate its object and doctrine; for they taught clearly and openly that the festival was celebrated for the Conception of the Vii-gin, and they con- demned as false and most foreign to the in- tention of the Church the opinion of those who considered and aflBirmed that it was not the Conception itself, but the sanctification, to which devotion was paid by the Church. Nor did they think of treating more leniently those who, in order to weaken the doctrine

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of the Immaculate Conception, drawing a dis- tinction between the first and second instant of the Conception, asserted that the Concep- tion was indeed celebrated, but not its first moment; for Our predecessors themselves thought it their duty to protect and defend with all zeal both the Feast of the Conception of the Most Blessed Virgin, and the Concep- tion at the first instant, as the true object of the cuUus. Hence the words in which Alex- ander YII. declared the intention of the Church, saying, "Certainly, it is the ancient piety of the Faithful of Christ towards His Most Blessed Mother the Virgin Mary, be- lieving that her soul, in the first instant of its creation, and infusion into the body, was by a special grace and privilege of God, in virtue of the merits of Jesus Christ her Son the Kedeemer of mankind, preserved free from the stain of original sin, and in this sense they keep and cele-

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brate with solemn rite the Festival of Her Conception."

Our predecessors thought it their duty to preserve from contention the doctrine of the Immaculate Conception of the Mother of Grod ; and guarded and protected it with all care and zeal. For not only have they never suflfered that this doctrine should be censured or traduced in any way, but they have gone much farther, and in clear declarations on repeated occasions they have proclaimed that the doctrine in which we confess the Im- maculate Conception of the Virgin, is of its own merit, to be held in veneration, that it is of ancient and nearly universal belief, which the Boman Church has undertaken to cherish and protect, and, above all, worthy to be placed in its sacred liturgy and its solemn prayers. Not content with this, in order that the doctrine of the Immaculate Concep- tion of the Virgin should remain inviolate.

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they have most severely prohibited the opi- nion adverse to this doctrine to be defended either in public or in private, and they have wished to destroy it, as it were, by repeated wounds. To which reiterated and most clear declarations, lest they might appear empty, they added a sanction; all which things Our illustrious predecessor, Alexander VL, em- braced in these words: —

"Considering that the Holy Eoman Church solemnly

celebrates the Festival of the Con- ception of the Immaculate and Ever Blessed Virgin, and has appointed for this a special and proper office according to the f)ious, de- vout, and laudable institution which ema- nated from Our predecessor, Sixtus IV., and wishing, after the example of the Eoman Pontiffs, Our Predecessors, to favor this laud- able piety, and devotion, and the reverence shown towards it, in the Roman Church in- variably, since the institution of the honor

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itself; in order also to protect this devout practice of venerating and celebrating the Most Blessed Virgin, preserved from original sin by the preventing grace of the Holy Ghost, and desiring to preserve in the flock of Christ unity of spirit in the bond of peace, removing offences, and scandals ; at the instance and •prayers of the said Bishops, with the Chap- ters of their Churches, and of King Philip and his kingdom — We renew the constitu- tions and decrees issued by the Eoman PontiflFs, Our Predecessors, and especially by Sixtus lY., Paul V., and Gregory XV., in favor of the opinion that the Soul of the Blessed Virgin, in its creation and infusion into the body, was endowed with the grace of the Holy Ghost, and preserved from ori- ginal sin; likewise, also, in favor of the Fes- tival of the same Virgin Mother of God, cele- brated according to that pious belief which is recited above; and We command that it

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shall be observed under the censures and pe- nalties contained in the same constitutions. "And against all and each of those who try to interpret the aforesaid constitutions or decrees so that they may frustrate the favor shown through these to the said belief, and to the festival or cfuJtus celebrated according to it, or who try to recall into dispute the same belief, festival, or calbas^ or against these in any manner, either directly or indirectly, and on any pretext, even that of examining the grounds, of defining it, or of explaining or interpreting the Sacred Scriptures, or the Holy Fathers or Doctors; in fine, who should dare, under any pretext or on any occasion whatsoever, to say either in writing, or by word of mouth to preach, to treat, to dis- pute, by determining or asserting any thing against these, or by bringing arguments against them, and leaving these arguments unanswered, or by expressing dissent in any

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other possible manner; besides the punish ments and censures contained in the consti- tutions of Sixtus IV., we desire to add, and by these presents do add, that they should be deprived ipso facto, and without other de- claration, of the faculty, of preaching, of lectur- ing in public, or of teaching and interpreting, and also of their voice, whether active or pas- sive, in elections ; from which censures they cannot be absolved, nor obtain dispensation, unless from TJs, or Our successors, the Eoman Pontiffs; likewise we wish to subject, and we hereby do subject, the same persons to other penalties to be inflicted at Our will, and at that of the same Eoman Pontiffs, Our Succes- sors, renewing the constitutions or decrees of Paul V. and Gregory XV., above mentioned. "And We prohibit, under the penalties and censures contained in the Index of Prohibited Books, and We will and declare to be es- teemed prohibited ipso facto, and without

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other declaration, books in which the afore said belief and the festival or devotion cele- brated according to it is called into dispute, or in which any thing whatever is written or read against these, or lectures, sermons, treatises, and disputations against the same, published after the decree above eulogized of Paul v., or to be published at any fixture time."

All are aware with how much zeal this doctrine of the ImmaculaTte Conception of the Mother of God has been handed down, asseiied, and propagated by the most distin- guished Religious Orders, the most celebrated theological academies, and the most eminent Doctors of the science of Divinity. All know likewise how anxious have been the Bishops openly and publicly to profess, even in the Ecclesiastical assemblies themselv-es, that the Most Holy Mother of God the Virgin Mary, by virtue of the merits of Christ our

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Lord, the Saviour of mankind, never lay un- der original sin, bufrwas preserved free from the stain of guilt, and was thus redeemed in a more sublime manner. To which, lastly, is added this fact, more grave, and in an es- pecial manner, most important of all, that * the Council of Trent itself, when it promul- gated the dogmatical decree concerning original sin, in which, according to the testi- monies of the Sacred Scriptures, of the Holy Fathers, and of the most approved councils, it determined and defined that all mankind are bom under original sin; solemnly de- clared, however, that it was not its intention to include in the decree itself, and in the amplitude of its definition, the Blessed and Inmiaculate Virgin Mary, Mother of God. Indeed, by this declaration, the Tridentine Fathers have asserted, according to the times and the circumstances of affairs, that the Blessed Virgin Mary was free from the

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original stain, and thus clearly signified that nothing could be justly adduced from the sacred writings, nor from the authority of the Fathers, which would in any way gain- say so great a prerogative of the Virgin.

And, in truth, illustrious monuments of a venerated antiquity of the Eastern and of the Western Church most powerfully testify that this doctrine of the Immaculate Con- ception of the Most Blessed Virgin, every day more and more so splendidly explained and confirmed

by the highest authority, teaching, zeal, science, and wisdom of the Church, and so wonderfully propagated amongst all the nations and peoples of the Catholic world, always existed in the Church as received from Our ancestors, and stamped with the character of a Divine revelation. For the Church of Christ, careful guardian and defender of the dogmas deposited with her, changes nothing in them, diminishes

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nothing, adds nothing, but, with all industry, by faithfully and wisely treating ancient things, so studies to limit and perfect their expression, that these ancient dogmas of heavenly faith may receive evidence, light, distinction, but may still retain their fulness, integrity, and propriety, and may increase only in their own kind, that is, in the same sense and the same belief.

The Fathers and writers of the Church, taught by the heavenly writings, had nothing more at heart, in the books written to ex-

plain the Scriptures, to vindicate the dog- mas, and to instruct the Faithful, than emu- lously to declare and exhibit in many and wonderful ways the Virgin's most high sanc- tity, dignity, and freedom from all stain of original sin, and Her renowned victory over the most foul enemy of the human race. Wherefore, repeating the words in which, at the beginning of the world, the Almighty,

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announcing the remedies of His mercy, pre- pared for regenerating mankind, crushed the audacity of the lying serpent, and wonder- fully, raised up the hope of our race, saying — "I will place enmity between thee and the Woman, thy seed and hers," they taught that in this Divine oracle was clearly and openly pointed out the merciful Kedeemer of the human race — the only-begotten Son of God, Christ Jesus, and that his Most Blessed Mother, the Virgin Mary, was designated, and at the same time that the enmity of both against the serpent was signally ex- pressed. Wherefore, as Christ, the Mediator of Grod and men, having assumed human na- ture, blotting out the handwriting of the de- cree which stood against us, fastened it tri- umphantly to the Cross, so the Most Holy Virgin, bound by a most close and indisso- luble chain to Him, exercising with Him and through Him eternal enmity against the

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malignant serpent, and triumphing most thoroughly over the same, has crushed his. head with Her Immaculate foot.

This illustrious and singular triumph of the Virgin, and her most exalted innocence, purity, and holiness, Her freedom from all stain of sin, and ineffable abundance of all heavenly graces, virtues, and privileges, the same fathers beheld in that ark of Noah which, divinely appointed, escaped safe and sound, from the common shipwreck of the whole world; also in that ladder which Jacob beheld reaching from earth to Heaven, by whose steps the Angels of God ascended and descended, on whose top leaned God himself; also in that bush which, in the holy place, Moses beheld blaze on every side, and amidst the crackling flames, neither consumed nor suflFering the least injury ; also in that tower raiassailable in the face of an enemy, from which depend a thousand bucklers and all

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the armor of the brave ; also in that garden fenced round about, which cannot be violated nor corrupted by any schemes of fraud; also in that brilliant city of God, whose founda- tions are in the holy mounts; also in that most august temple of God, which, shining with divine splendor, is filled with the glory of God; likewise in many other things of this kind, which the Fathers have handed down, that the exalted dignity of the Mo- ther of God, and her spotless innocence and holiness, obnoxious to no blemish, have been signally pre-announced.

To describe the same totality, as it were, of Divine gifts, and the original integrity of the Virgin, of whom Jesus was bom, the same Fathers, using the eloquence of the Prophets, celebrate the august Virgin as the spotless dove, the holy Jerusalem, the ex- alted throne of Crod, the ark and house of sanctification, which Eternal Wisdom built

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for itself; and as that Queen who, abounding in delights and leaning on her beloved, came forth entirely perfect from the mouth of the Most High, fair and most dear to God, and never stained with the least spot. But when the same Fathers and the writers of the Church revolved in their hearts and minds that the Most Blessed Virgin, in the name and by the order of God himself, was pro- claimed full of grace by the Angel Gabriel, when announcing Her most sublime dignity of the Mother of God, they taught that, by this singular and solemn salutation, never heard on any other occasion, is shown that the Mother of God is the seal of all Divine graces, and adorned with all the gifts of the Holy Ghost — ^yea, the infinite storehouse and inexhaustible abyss of the same gifts; so that, pever obnoxious to an evil word, and alone with her Son partaker of perpetual

benediction. She deserved to hear from Eliza- p

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beth, inspired by the Holy Ghost, " Blessed art thou amongst women, and blessed is the Fruit of thy womb."

Hence it is the clear and unanimous opinion of the same that the Most Glorious Virgin, for whom He who is powerful has done great things, has shone with such a brilliancy of all heavenly gifts, such fulness of grace and such innocence, that She has been an ineffable miracle of the Almighty, yea, the crown of all miracles,

and worthy Mother of God; that She approaches as nearly to God as created nature can do, and is exalted above all human and angelic eulogies.

And therefore to vindicate the original in- nocence and justice of the Mother of (Jod, they not only compared Her to Eve as yet virgin, as yet innocent, as yet incorrupt, and not yet deceived by the deadly snares of the most treacherous serpent, but they have

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extolled Her witli a wonderful variety of thonglit and expression. For Eve, miserably obeying the serpent, fell from original inno- cence, and became his slave, but the Most Blessed Virgin, continually increasing her ^ original gift, not only never lent an ear to the serpent, but by a virtue divinely received utterly broke his power.

Wherefore they have never ceased to call the Mother of Grod the Lily amongst the thorns, earth entirely untouched, Virgin un- defiled, immaculate, ever blessed, and free from all contagion of sin, from which was formed the new Adam, a reproachless, most sweet paradise of innocence, immortality, and delights planted by God Himself, and fenced from all snares of the malignant ser- pent, incorruptible Branch that the worm of sin hath never injured; Fountain ever clear, and sealed by the virtue of the Holy Ghost, a most Divine Temple, or Treasure of im-

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mortality, or the sole and only Daughter not of Death but of Life, the Seed not of enmity but of grace, which by the singular provi- dence of Grod, has always flourished, budding from a corrupt and infected root, contrary to the settled and common laws. But as if these encomiums, though most splendid, were not sufficient, they proclaimed in proper and defined opinions that when sin should be treated of, no question should be entertained concerning the Holy Virgin Mary, to whom an abundance of grace was given to conquer sin completely. They also declared that the Most Glorious Virgin was the reparatrix of Her parents, the vivifier of posterity, chosen before ages, prepared for Himself by the Most High, predicted by God when He said to the serpent, " I will place enmity between thee and the Woman," who undoubtedly has crushed the poisonous head of the same serpent; and therefore they

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afl&rm that the same Blessed Virgin was through grace perfectly free from every stain of sin, and from all contagion of body, and soul, and mind, and, always conversant with Grod, and united with Him in an eternal cove- nant, was never in darkness but always in light, and therefore was plainly a fit habi- tation for Christ, not on account of Her bodily estate, but on account of original grace.

To these things are added the noble words, in which, speaking of the Conception of the Virgin, they have testified that Nature yielded to Grace and stood trembling, not being able to proceed further ; for it was to be that the Virgin Mother of God should not be conceived by Anna before grace should bear fruit. For She ought thus to be con- ceived as the first-born, from whom should be conceived the First-Bom of every crea- ture. They have testified that the flesh of

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the Virgin, taken from Adam, did not admit the stains of Adam, and on this account that the Most Blessed Virgin was the tabernacle created by God himself formed by the Holy Spirit, truly enriched with purple which that new Beseleel made, adorned and woven with gold ; and that this same Virgin is, and is deservedly, celebrated, as She who was the first and peculiar work of (xod, concealed from the fiery weapons of evil, fair by nature, and entirely free from all stain, came into the world all shining like the mom in her Immaculate Conception; nor, truly, was it right that this Vessel of Election should be assailed by common injuries, since, differing much from others, she had community with them only in their nature, not in their fault. Far more, it was right that, as the Only Begotten had a Father in Heaven, whom the Seraphim extol as thrice holy, so He should have a Mother on the earth, who never

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should want the splendor of holiness. And this doctriue, indeed, so filled the minds and souls of our forefathers, that a marvellous and singular form of speech prevailed with them, in which they very frequently called the Mother of Grod immaculate and entirely immaculate, innocent and most innocent, spotless, holy, and most distant from etery stain of sin, all pure, all perfect, the Type and Model of purity and innocence, more beautiful than beauty, more gracious than grace, more holy than holiness, alone holy and most pure in soul and body, who has surpassed all perfectitude and all virginity, and has become the dwelling-place of all the graces of the Most Holy Spirit, and who, God alone excepted, is superior to all, and by nature fairer, more beautiful, and more holy than the Cherubim and Seraphim; She, whom all the tongues of Heaven and earth do not suffice to extol. No one is ignorant

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that these fonns of speech have passed, as it were, spontaneously into the monuments of the most holy Liturgy, and the Ofl&ees of the Church, and that they occur often in them; since the Mother of Grod is invoked and named in them as a spotless Dove of beauty, as a Kose ever blooming and perfectly pure, ever spotless and ever blessed, and is cele- brated as Innocence which was never wounded, and a second Eve who brought forth Emmanuel.

It is no wonder, then, if the Pastors of the Church and the faithful people have daily more and more gloried to profess with so much piety and fervor this doctrine of the Immaculate Conception of the Virgin Mother of Grod, pointed out in the Sacred Scriptures, according to the judgment of the Fathers, handed down in so many mighty testimonies of the same, expressed and celebrated in so many illustrious monuments of revered an-

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tiqnity, arid proposed, and with great piety confirmed by the greatest and highest judg- ment of the Church ; so that nothing would be more dear or more pleasing to the same than everywhere to venerate, invoke, and proclaim the Virgin Mother of God conceived without original stain. Wherefore from the ancient times tlie Princes of the Church, Ecclesiastics, and even emperors and kings themselves, have earnestly en- treated of this Apostolic See that the Immaculate Conception of the Most Holy Mother of God should be defined as a dogma of Catholic faith. Which entreaties were re- newed also in these Our times, and especially were addressed to Gregory XVL, Our predecessor of happy memory, and to Ourselves, not only by Bishops, but by the Secular Clergy, Eeligious Oi'ders, and the greatest princes and faithful peoples.

Therefore with singular joy of mind, well

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knowing all these things, and seriously con- sidering them, scarcely had We, though un- worthy, been raised by a mysterious dispen- sation of Divine Providence to the exalted Chair of Peter, and undertaken the government of the whole Church, than, following the veneration, the piety, and love We had entertained for the Blessed Virgin from Our tender years. We had nothing at heart more than to accomplish all these things which as yet were amongst the ardent wishes of the Church, that the honor of the Most Blessed Virgin should be increased, and her preroga- tives should shine with a fuller light. But wishing to bring to this full maturity We appointed a special congregation ©f our Ve- nerable Brethren the Cardinals of the Holy Roman Church, illustrious by their piety, their wisdom, and their knowledge of the sacred sciences, and we also selected Eccle- siastics, both Secular and Regular, well

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trained in theological studies, most carefully to weigh all those things which relate to the Immaculate Conception of the Virgin, and report to us their opinion. And, although from the entreaties lately received by us to at length define the Immaculate Concep- tion of the Virgin the opinions of most of the Bishops of the Church were understood : yet We sent Encyclical Letters, dated at Gaeta, the 2nd day of February, in the year 1849, to all our Venerable Brethren, the Bishops of the Catholic world, in order that having oflFered prayers to God they might signify to Us, in writing, what was the piety and devotion, of their flocks towards the Im- maculate Conception of the Mother of God, and especially what the Bishops themselves thought about promulgating the Definition, or what they desired, in order that We might pronounce Our supreme judgment as solemnly as possible.

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Certainly we were filled with no slight consolation when the replies of our Vene- rable Brethren came to Us. For, with an incredible joyfulness, gladness, and zeal, they not only confirmed their own singular piety, and that of their Clergy and faithful people, towards the Immaculate Conception of the Most Blessed Virgin, but they even entreated of Us with a common voice that the Immaculate Conception of the Virgin should be defined by Our supreme judgment and authority. Nor, indeed, were we filled with less joy when our Venerable Brethren of Our Holy Eoman Church, the Cardinals of the Special Congregation aforesaid, and the consulting Theologians chosen by Us, after a diligent examination demanded of Us with equal alacrity and zeal this definition of the Immaculate Conception of the Mother of Gk)d.

Afterwards treading in the illustrious foot-

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steps of Our Predecessors, and desiring to proceed duly and properly, We proclaimed and held a Consistory, in which We addressed Our Brethren, the Cardinals of the Holy Ro- man Church, and with the greatest consola- tion of mind We heai-d them entreat of Us that We should promulgate the dogmatic definition of the Immaculate Conception of the Virgin Mother of God.

Therefore, having full trust in the Lord that the fitting time had now come for defin- ing the Immaculate Conception of the Vir- gin Mary, Mother of God, which the Divine words, venerable tradition, the perpetual opmion of the Church, the singular agree- ment of Catholic Prelates and Faithful, and the signal acts and constitutions of Our Pre- decessors wonderfiilly illustrate and proclaim ; having most diligently weighed all things, and poured forth to God assiduous and fervent prayers. We resolved that we should no

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longer delay to sanction and define, by Our supreme authority, the Immaculate ConcepT tion of the Virgin, and thus to satisfy the most pious desires of the Catholic world and Our own piety towards the Most Holy Virgin, and, at the same time, to honor more and more the Only-Begotten Son, Jesus Christ our Lord, since whatever honor and praise are given to the Mother redound to the Son.

Wherefore, after we had unceasingly, in humility and

fasting, offered Our own prayers and the public prayers of the Church to God the Father, through His Son, that He would deign to direct and confirm Our mind by the power of the Holy Ghost, and having im- plored the aid of the entire Heavenly Host, and invoked the Paraclete with sighs, and He thus inspiring, to the honor of the Holy and undivided Trinity, to the glory and adornment of the Virgin Mother of God, to the exaltation of the Catholic Faith and the

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increase of the Catholic religion, by the au- thority of Jesus Christ Our Lord, of the Blessed Apostles, Peter and Paul, We declare, pronounce, and define that the doctrine which holds that the Blessed Virgin Mary, at the fii-st instant of her conception, by a singular privilege and grace of the Omnipotent God, in virtue of the merits of Jesus Christ, the Saviour of mankind, was preserved immacu- late fix)m all stain of original sin, has been revealed by God, and therefore should firmly and constantly be believed by all the faith- ful • Wherefore if any shall dare — which God avert — ^to think otherwise than as it has been defined by Us, let them know and un- derstand that they are condemned by their own judgment, that they have suffered ship- wreck of the faith, and have revolted from the unity of the Church; and besides by their own act, they subject themselves to the penalties justly established if what they think

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they should dare to signify by woixi, writing, or any other outward means.

Our mouth is filled with joy and Our tongue with exultation, and We return, and shall ever return, the most humble and the great- est thanks to Jesus Christ Our Lord, because through His singular beneficence He has granted to us, though unworthy, to offer and decree this honor, glory, and praise to His Most Holy Mother. We rely, moreover, with most cei-tain hope and confidence that this Most Blessed Virgin, who, all fair and im- maculate, has bruised the poisonous head of the most malignant sei-pent, and brought salvation to the world, who is the praise of the Prophets and the Apostles, the honor of the Martyrs, and the crown and joy of all the Saints — ^who is the safest Befuge and most faithful Helper of all who are in danger, and the most powerful Mediatrix and Conciliatrix in the whole world, with Her Only-Begotten

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Son, and the most illustrious Glory, Orna- ment, and most firm Defence of the Holy Church, who has destroyed all heresies, and snatched from the greatest calamities of all kinds the faithful peoples and nations, and delivered Us from so many threatening dan- gers, will effect, by Her most powerful pa- tronage that, all difficulties being removed, and all errors dissipated, Our Holy Mother the Catholic Church may flourish daily more and more throughout all nations and coun- tries, and may reign from sea to sea and to the ends of the earth, and may enjoy all peace, tranquillity, and liberty ; that the sin- ful may obtain pardon, the sick healing, the weak strength of heart, the afflicted consola- tion, and that all who are in error, their spi- ritual bUndness being dissipated, may return to the path of truth and justice, and may be- come one flock and one shepherd.

Let all the children of the Catholic Church

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most dear to Us hear these Our words, and, with a more ardent zeal of piety, religion, and love, proceed to honor, invoke, and pray to the Most Blessed Virgin Mary, Mother of Grod, conceived without original sin ; and let them fly with entire confidence to this most sweet Mother of Mercy and Grace in all dan- gers, difficulties, doubts, and fears. For no- thing is to be feared, and nothing is to be despaired of under Her guidance, under Her auspices, under Her favor, under Her protec- tion, who, bearing towards us a Mother's love, and taking up the work of our salva- tion, is solicitous for the whole human race, and, appointed by Grod, Queen of Heaven and Earth, and exalted above all the choirs of Angels, and orders of Saints, standing at the Right Hand of the Only-Begotten Son, Jesus Christ Our Lord, intercedes most pow- fully, and obtains what she asks, and can- not fail.

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Finally, in order that this Our definition of the Immaenlate Conception of the Most Blessed Virgin Mary may be brought to the knowledge of the universal Church, We will that these Letters Apostolic do stand for a perpetual remembrance of the same, com- manding that to transcripts or printed co- pies, subscribed by the hand of some notary public, and authenticated by the seal of a person of Ecclesiastical rank, appointed for the purpose, the same credit shall be given which would be given to these presents if they were exhibited or shown.

Let no man presume to infringe this Our declaration, pronunciation, and definition, or to oppose and contradict it with presumptuous rashness. If any should presume to assail it, let him know that he will incur the indig- nation of the Omnipotent God and of His blessed Apostles Peter and Paul.

Given at Borne, at Saint Peter's, in the year of the Incarnation of Our Lord, MDCCCLIV., the sixth of the Ides of Decem- ber, in the ninth year of our Pontificate.

PIUS PP. IX.

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